INVESTOR BRIEF · TRUSTMRR VERIFIED-REVENUE DATASET · N = 1,000 · FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

The 5% Economy

1,000 indie startups with payment-verified revenue. The data shows a brutal power law — **and exactly what wins, and where to buy in.**

$15.6M

combined verified revenue, last 30 days

$400

the median startup's monthly revenue

75%

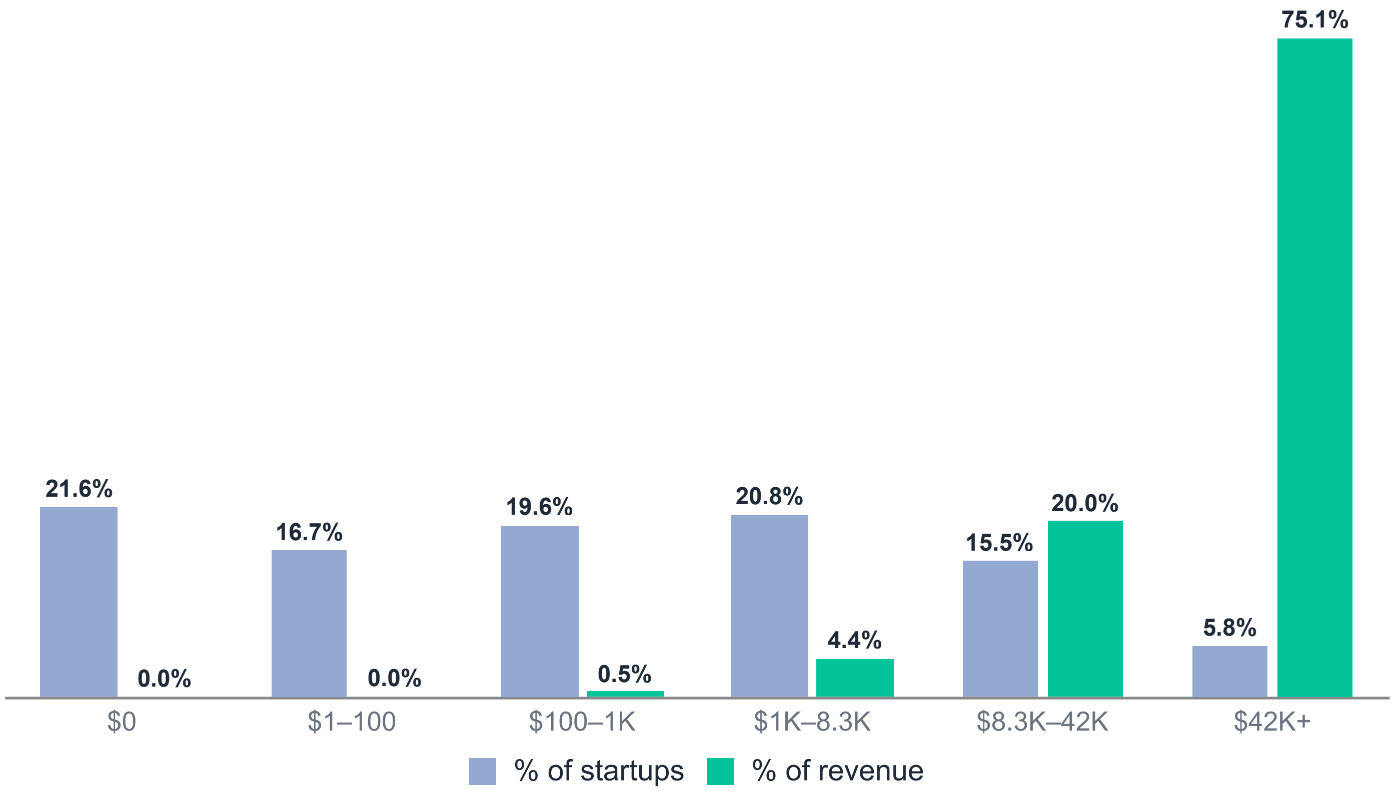
of all revenue earned by the top 5.8% of startups

2.4×

median asking price on for-sale startups (× revenue)

A power law, not a bell curve

Share of startups vs share of combined 30-day revenue, by monthly-revenue tier · $8.3K/mo ≈ $100K ARR pace



50%

of all revenue comes from just 10 startups.

38%

of startups earn less than $100 a month.

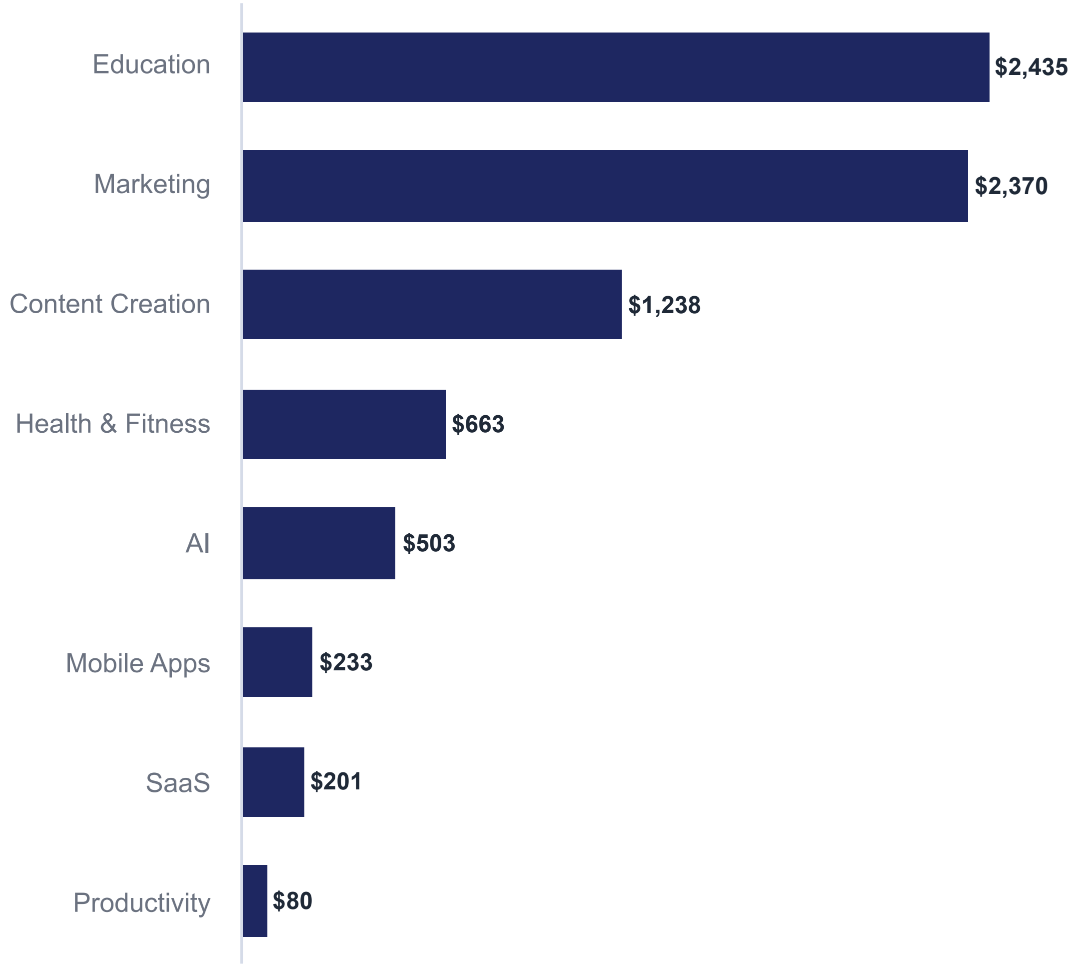
0%

median MRR growth — only the $42K+ tier is still compounding (+0.7%).

A blind pick has a 1-in-17 chance of hitting the tier that earns 75% of the money — own a basket, not a bet.

Hype doesn’t pay. Pricing power does.

Median monthly revenue by category (categories with ≥30 startups) · winner traits from the top-100 earners



MYTH

“An audience = revenue”

Follower count barely correlates with revenue (r = 0.18). Half of the top-100 earners have ≤ 212 followers on X.

MYTH

“‘AI’ is the opportunity”

AI is the most crowded label — 27% of categorized startups — yet its median is $503/mo, ~5× below Education and Marketing tools.

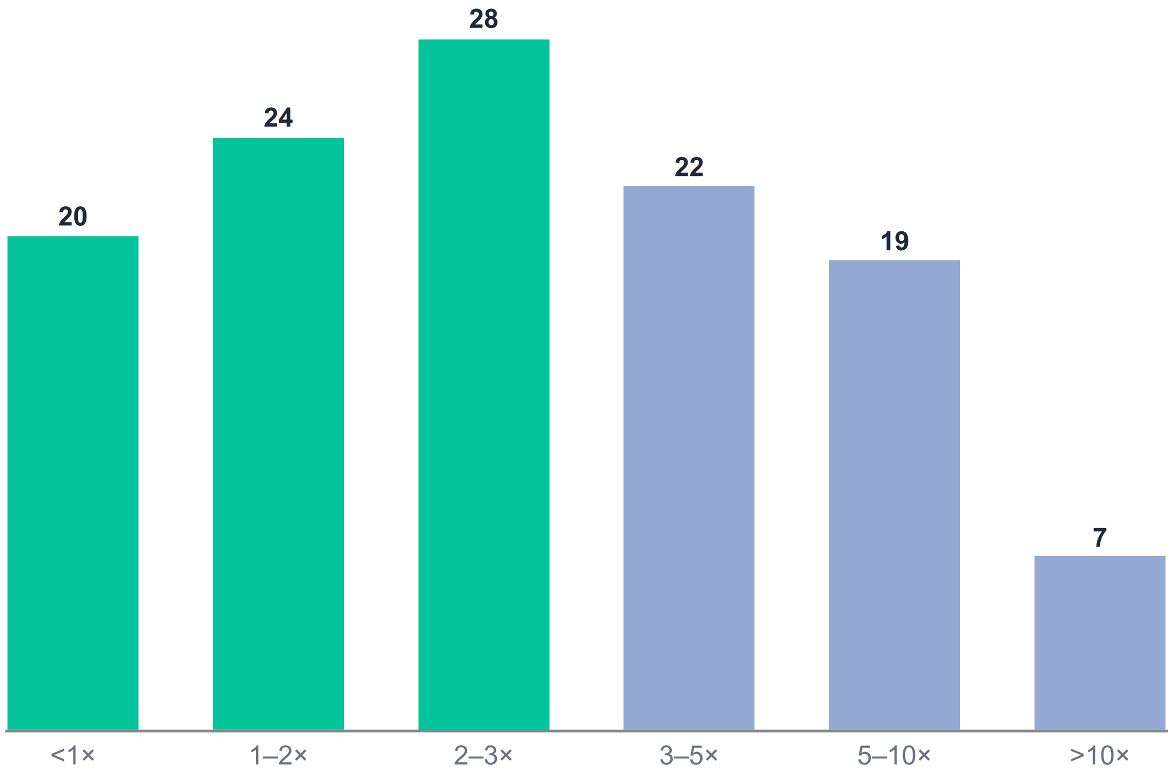
SIGNAL

B2B + pricing power

B2B is 36% of the market but 55% of the top 100. Median B2B revenue is 4× B2C ($1,240 vs $304), and top-100 ARPU is $53 vs a $20 norm.

The entry point: cash flow at 2.4× revenue

Asking price as a multiple of trailing-12-month revenue — for-sale listings with ≥ $10K verified revenue (n = 120)



60% of real-revenue listings ask ≤ 3× trailing revenue.

26% of the entire dataset is openly for sale — 262 startups with $20.5M in combined trailing revenue.

2.4× median ask on trailing revenue (IQR 1.5–4.7×). Public-SaaS benchmark: ~6× (BVP Cloud Index).

PRICED-IN RISK

Only 29% of these listings are still growing MRR. The discount is real — and so is the reason. Diversify, and pay ≤ 3×.

Public SaaS: ~6× revenue. Verified micro-SaaS: 2.4× — the discount is the fee for doing the filtering yourself.

Buy the basket, not the lottery ticket

The same dataset yields the screen: from 1,000 startups to 46 investable targets.

1,000	verified startups
387	≥ $10K trailing revenue
209	…and ≥ $1K MRR, not shrinking
65	…and openly for sale
46	**…and asking ≤ 3× revenue**

1. **Own the power law**

   Back 15–25 names, not one. The top tier's 75% revenue share does the compounding for you.

2. **Screen on economics, not hype**

   B2B, ~$50 ARPU, payment-verified revenue. Ignore follower counts and buzzwords — they don't correlate.

3. **Pay ≤ 3× trailing revenue**

   At the 2.4× median, flat revenue pays back in ~2½ years — and one breakout carries the whole basket.

Source: TrustMRR frozen dataset, 30 Jul 2026 (n = 1,000; revenue verified via payment providers). Public-SaaS benchmark: BVP Nasdaq Emerging Cloud Index. Illustrative analysis, not investment advice.